

The camera

Pinhole cameras were used in ancient times to project images, but they couldn't take a picture—that had to wait until the 1820s. The first photographs took several hours of exposure in the camera. Now, with digital technology, we can take pictures and view them instantly.

WOW!

The earliest known photograph was taken by Joseph Nicéphore Niépce in 1826. It shows the view from an upstairs window at his country estate in France.

SILVER SHOTS

Daguerreotype images, like this one (right) from 1843, were made by exposing a silver-coated copper plate for a few minutes. The faint image was developed to full visibility using mercury fumes. William Fox Talbot created the “calotype,” another early photographic process, in 1841. Unlike the daguerreotype, an unlimited number of prints could be made from one calotype.



An aperture allows light into the camera.

THE FIRST SNAPS

The first photographs, taken by Joseph Nicéphore Niépce in the 1820s, were very crude. It was his colleague, Louis Daguerre, who developed the first viable photographic process. The 1839 Giroux Daguerreotype was the world's first commercially produced camera.

A tripod holds the camera steady during the exposure.

**Giroux
Daguerreotype, 1839**

CAMERA OBSCURA

The camera obscura, a bigger version of the simple pinhole camera, was refined in 1570. Inside a dark room, a tiny hole is made in one wall. Natural light is focused through it, and an image of the outside scene is projected onto the opposite wall. There is a working example (left) in Edinburgh, Scotland.